

Deepa Palaniappan

CV / 2026
APRIL
THREE PAGES

DISABILITY INCLUSION · ACCESSIBILITY ·
POLICY

DISABILITY-RIGHTS-REPOSITORY.ORG
EQUITABLEDOCS.ORG
EQUITABLEDOCS.ORG
BENGALURU / INDIA

01 SUMMARY

On disability-inclusive development.

Currently **Advisor - Inclusion, Systems & Partnerships at Snehadhara Foundation**, Bengaluru. Most recently completed a tenure as Assistant Professor then Consultant with the **Office of Disability Inclusion at Azim Premji University** (Dec 2022 - Mar 2026). Two assignments with the **WHO Disability Unit in Geneva** contributed to the **Global Report on Health Equity for Persons with Disabilities** (2022); World Bank work on the TN RIGHTS project supported the Government of Tamil Nadu; earlier, as State Disability Consultant in Bihar, I developed the **State Disability Inclusion Guideline**, in implementation since August 2020.

02 HIGHLIGHTS

A few highlights.

PROJECT

Disability Rights Repository

A small portal I maintain, to give visibility to community-based grassroots practitioners and support documentation by OPD leaders and patient advocates.

INITIATIVE

EquitableDocs

A non-commercial pipeline for accessible academic content for students with print disabilities in Global South institutions. Free for individuals and government; cost-only for institutions.

EARLIER WORK

Bihar Disability Inclusion Guideline

Developed during my time as State Disability Consultant with JEEViKA; in implementation across the State Rural Livelihoods Mission since August 2020.

CERTIFICATION

CPACC - IAAP Certified Professional in Accessibility Core Competencies

And Disability Rights & Accessibility certification, US Institute of Diplomacy & Human Rights (Washington, DC). Trained in complex-PDF, InDesign, Word, Excel and PowerPoint accessibility remediation.

03 CURRENTLY

In post.

2024 →
Present
BENGALURU

Advisor, Inclusion, Systems & Partnerships

Snehadhara Foundation

Inclusion within partner organisations; accessibility advisory across programmes, spaces and documentation.

2026 →
State commission
GOVT. OF TN

Drafting committee member

State Disability Policy, Department for the Welfare of Differently Abled, Government of Tamil Nadu (two-member committee)

Active
National standards
GOVT. OF INDIA

Member, Disability Informatics Sub-Committee MHD 17:3

Bureau of Indian Standards - Medical Equipment & Hospital Planning Division Council

Active
Certification body

Technical Committee member

Purple Building Certification Scheme - accessibility rating for public buildings (launched April 2025)

Experience.

FROM JEEVIKA BIHAR TO WHO GENEVA.

CONTINUED →

2022 - 2026

Dec → Mar
BENGALURU

Assistant Professor, then Consultant

Office of Disability Inclusion, Azim Premji University

Assistant Professor Dec 2022 - Jul 2025 · *Consultant* Jul 2025 - Mar 2026.

- Initiated and developed the reasonable-accommodation process, and disability-inclusion and accessibility interventions across the University.
- Designed and delivered training and faculty-development sessions; liaised with faculty, departments and external experts.

2023

Aug → Dec
GENEVA · 2ND

Consultant

WHO HQ Disability Unit, Geneva

Review of WHO documents for disability-inclusion components; mapping of DPOs across countries with focus on LMICs.

2021 - 2022

Oct → Sep
GENEVA · 1ST

Consultant

WHO HQ Disability Unit, Geneva

Scoping review on health emergencies and disability inclusion, in support of the WHO *Global Report on Health Equity for Persons with Disabilities* (2022); coordinated ISL interpreters during stakeholder consultations.

2021 - 2022

TN RIGHTS
GOVT. OF TN

Consultant

World Bank - Government of Tamil Nadu

Initiated and facilitated a CBR core group toward a draft CBR policy submitted to the State partner; supported the TN team on the CBR implementation plan and accessibility inputs to the OMIP.

2022

May → Jun
SHORT-TERM

Consultant

UN OHCHR - Mandate of the Special Rapporteur on the elimination of discrimination against persons affected by leprosy

Policy compilation and analysis on inclusion of leprosy-affected persons in global disability policy; report on leprosy and disability rights in the Global South.

2020

Oct → Dec
GENEVA

Research Intern

International Disability Alliance · short-term research, Light for the World

2018 / 2020

Two postings
BIHAR

State Disability Consultant

JEEViKA - State Rural Livelihoods Mission, Government of Bihar

Mainstreamed disability inclusion across the state poverty-alleviation programme. *Authored the Disability Inclusion Guideline, in implementation since August 2020.*

2018

ODISHA

Disability Resource Person

Odisha Livelihoods Mission - Panchayati Raj & Drinking Water Dept.

Training modules, staff sensitisation, and a three-day district/block orientation workshop.

2011 - 2017

Earlier
INDIA

EARLIER ROLES

2016-17

State Disability Consultant, Sightsavers India (Bihar) - Sightsavers-BRLPS partnership; SHG micro-plans; financial-inclusion workshops; district / block staff training.

2016

National Volunteer, VSO Action Research Project (Jharkhand) - 'Enhancing Employability of Youth with Disabilities through Inclusive ITI Curriculum', published in *Empowering Children with Disabilities*.

2014-15

Researcher / Documentation, Shanta Memorial Rehabilitation Centre - USAID WWDIN Project.

2013-16

Research Fellow, SDRS - Society for Disability and Rehabilitation Studies, New Delhi.

2011-13

SYLFF Fellow, Ryoichi Sasakawa Young Leaders Fund - JNU; mentor to Viklang Adhikar Manch (Bihar) and Divyang Adhikar Manch (Jharkhand).

Education, scholarship, service.

SELECTED - FULL LIST ON THE WEB CV.

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04 EDUCATION

Three degrees.

2019 - 2021

Full scholarship
GENEVA

Mid-career MA, Development Studies

Graduate Institute Geneva (IHEID)

Thesis: a case study on the National Rural Livelihoods Mission and disability inclusion.

2003 - 2007

NEW DELHI

MA & MPhil, Political Science

Jawaharlal Nehru University

Dissertation: *Approaches to Disability - Norms, Discourse and Policy*.

2008 - 2009

NEW DELHI

PG Diploma, Special Education - Neurological Disorders & Multiple Disabilities

School of Rehabilitation Sciences, University of Delhi

05 SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

Books, chapters, journals.

- 01 'Enabling Policies', [Yojana](#), Publications Division, Govt. of India, Dec 2020.
- 02 Friedner, Ghosh & Palaniappan, "'Cross-Disability" in India? On the limits of disability as a category and the work of negotiating impairments', [SAMAJ](#).
- 03 Palaniappan & Rodrigues, 'Disability within the Rawlsian Framework of Justice', in A. Ghai (ed.), [Disability in South Asia: Knowledge and Experience](#), Sage, 2018.
- 04 Palaniappan & Guru, 'Skill Training for Adolescents with Disabilities', in Sonpal & Vaishnav (eds.), [Empowering Children with Disabilities](#).
- 05 'Inner Marginalities and Sub-Group Politicization within the Disability Movement', [Café Dissensus](#), Aug 2016.
- 06 'ICT4D and Accessibility', Natl. Symposium on Disability, Assistive Technology and Farming, ICAR-CIAE Bhopal, 2016.
- 07 Book Review, [International Journal of Disability Studies](#), Vol. 9, 2015.

06 CONVENING & CHAIRS

Selected.

- 01 Panelist, [World Health Innovation Forum](#), AMTZ Vishakapatnam, Dec 2025.
- 02 Moderator, World Health Innovation Forum, 12 Dec 2024.
- 03 Jury, [Assistive Technology Hackathon](#), KIHT x AMTZ, 7-9 Apr 2025.
- 04 Panel, 'Disability Justice: Looking Beyond Ableist Frames', IDSK Kolkata, Nov 2024.
- 05 Panel, [University of Chicago Delhi Centre](#) - 'Disentangling Disability and Human Rights'.
- 06 Session Chair, 'Attitudinal & Communication Barriers', JNU, Mar 2015.
- 07 Co-Chair, 'Disability and Barrier-free Toileting in Indian Railways', ISIC, Feb 2016.
- 08 Discussant, 'Disability and Social Inclusion', JNU.

07 FELLOWSHIPS & CERTIFICATIONS

A sample.

- 01 [NIEPID](#) - ex-General Council member, National Institute for the Empowerment of Persons with Intellectual Disabilities, nominated by Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment, Govt. of India.
- 02 [Distinguished Fellow](#), Kalam Institute of Health Technology - WHO Collaborating Centre at AMTZ (2023-2025).
- 03 [SYLFF Fellowship](#), Ryoichi Sasakawa Young Leaders Fund - JNU, 2010-2013.
- 04 [Sarai-CSDS Stipend](#), 2005-06 - 'Invisible in New Delhi'.
- 05 [IHEID full scholarship](#), Graduate Institute Geneva, 2019-2021.
- 06 [CPACC](#), IAAP.
- 07 [Built-Environment Accessibility](#), NITS / BIS Capsule, May 2025.
- 08 [FICCI DEI](#) Virtual Programme, Feb-Apr 2025.
- 09 [CII-IBDN](#) Disability-Inclusive Leaders @ Workplace, 2024.
- 10 [Assistive Technology Solutions](#), 6-mo. certificate, NISH Trivandrum, 2023.
- 11 WHO Quality Rights Training - Mental Health, Recovery and Community Inclusion.
- 12 Action Aid Intl. Training Course in Disability & Development, 2011.